



Two Faces of Mexico's Institutional Crisis

Contemporary Mexico reveals a paradoxical governance crisis operating through two opposing forces. From above, populist plebiscitarianism under President Andrés Manuel López Obrador strains traditional checks and balances. From below, criminal organizations like the *Cártel Jalisco Nueva Generación* erode territorial sovereignty and impose alternative governance structures.

Both phenomena challenge the Mexican state's monopoly on legitimate authority—one by politicizing popular legitimacy against institutions, the other by privatizing coercive power and local governance.

Plebiscitarianism and the Erosion of State Capacity

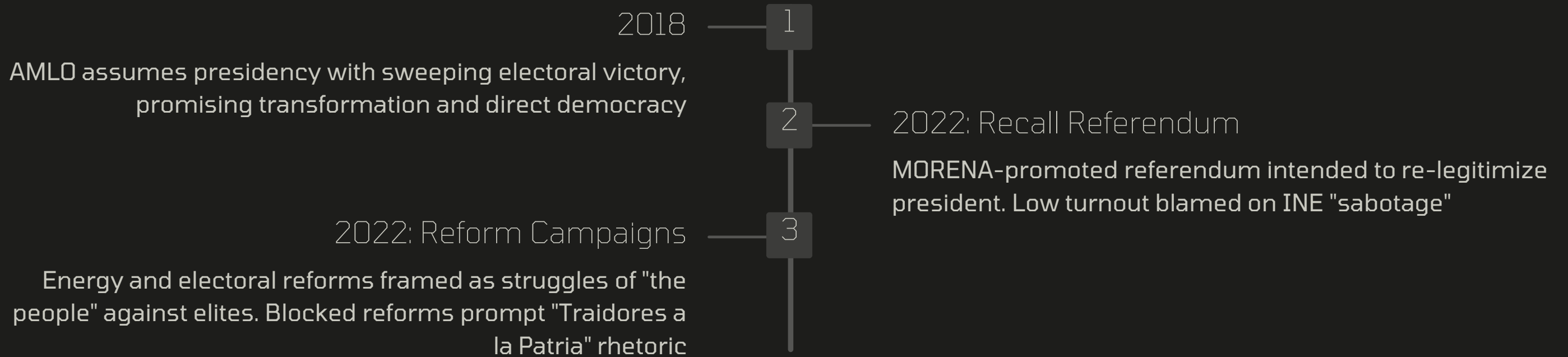
Since AMLO's 2018 victory, Mexico has faced two simultaneous "stress tests" that reveal the fragility of democratic governance:

- **Democratic backsliding:** Attempts to centralize power and delegitimize horizontal accountability institutions
- **State capacity erosion:** Deep insecurity, pervasive violence, and militarization of civilian life

The nuanced reality: democratic erosion has been contained, but state capacity erosion has intensified dramatically.



Belligerent Plebiscitarianism in Action



The Militarization Paradox

AMLO's most profound impact comes not through dismantling democracy, but through transforming the state itself—creating what scholars term a "hollow state."

Military Expansion

Armed forces now handle security, airport construction, customs operations, and major infrastructure like Tren Maya

Autonomous Agency Erosion

Budget cuts and unfilled appointments weaken oversight bodies: INE (elections), COFECE (antitrust), INAI (transparency), IFETEL (telecommunications)

Bureaucratic Hollowing

Technical and neutral capacities that stabilized Mexican governance reduced under efficiency and anti-corruption justifications

- ❏ Mexico's primary danger may not be authoritarianism but institutional depletion—a weakened administrative core increasingly reliant on military rather than civilian structures.

Criminal Governance: The CJNG Model

While the presidency expands plebiscitarian reach, the Cártel Jalisco Nueva Generación has built an alternative governance system combining violent coercion with selective legitimacy.

The CJNG exercises territorial control through:

- Paramilitary organization with disciplined structure
- Network alliances and flexible local ties
- Economic diversification beyond drug trafficking

By 2022, the CJNG operated in approximately 20% of Mexican municipalities, with international cells across continents.



Ruling Violently: Coercion and Legitimacy

Spectacular Violence

Public displays of brutality enforce obedience and deter rivals. Quasi-military tactics against state forces, including drones and armored convoys.

Media Propaganda

Strategic use of social media to broadcast power, create fear, and maintain internal cohesion through visibility.

Internal Discipline

Executions of traitors and forced recruitment create governance mechanism, not merely by-product of operations.

The Legitimacy Paradox

In areas of weak state presence, the CJNG provides rudimentary public goods: protection against petty crime, distribution of food and medicine during crises, and selective charity framed as "defending Mexicans" from corruption.

This produces paradoxical *criminal legitimacy*—citizens may tolerate or support the cartel in exchange for security and stability, creating dual sovereignty with the Mexican state.

Dual Erosion of State Authority

1

Plebiscitarianism

Populist executive challenges from above through politicization and militarization

2

Institutional Vacuum

Weak trust and uneven state presence create governance gaps

3

Criminal Governance

Organizations challenge from below through coercion and shadow institutions

Both logics reveal the same underlying crisis: the state loses capacity to govern through institutions, relying instead on personal, charismatic, or coercive forms of power.



Governing Through Fear and Faith

Mexico's governance crisis operates along two intertwined frontiers: the populist frontier where leaders claim to embody the nation directly, and the criminal frontier where nonstate actors fill vacuums with violence and patronage.

The Militarization Mirror

AMLO's reliance on armed forces as the most effective institution mirrors cartel logic: substituting rule-based authority with personalized or militarized control.

Hybrid Conditions Persist

Neither democracy nor state has collapsed, but both operate under duality: elections coexist with militarized governance; formal legality coexists with informal criminal rule.

The Path Forward

Citizen dissatisfaction, weak institutions, and uneven legitimacy form the soil where both populism and criminal governance thrive. Rebuilding trust requires transparency, social inclusion, and local security.

Reclaiming democratic institutions means addressing not only horizontal accountability but also the vertical legitimacy crisis that allows alternative forms of authority to flourish.